

AAM AASTHA: Indian Devotions
by Charles Fréger
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INDIA UP-CLOSE
Charkula dance in Mathura, Uttar Pradesh

CHARLES FRÉGER/ THAMES & HUDSON

Over the past two decades, Charles Fréger has taken literally hundreds of portraits in many corners of the world. In portrait photography, the subject knows they are being photographed; they consent and participate, aware of the camera and the photographer, aware that they are presenting themselves as they want to be seen. Fréger's portraits are often of people in uniform or, as here, of people wearing ritual masks and costumes. This is an interesting take on portraiture, to present people not as they are always, but as they are in special moments. *Aam Aastha*, shot entirely in India, shows us people celebrating—it's festival time in these pictures and we see ordinary people as dancers and performers playing roles, calling the gods to earth, mimicking sacred and revered animals, enacting beloved and well-known stories, stepping out of their lives and out of their mundane selves to become part of something transcendental, more significant. In these moments, we can believe that the three worlds come together, myths are alive, and gods, humans and demons inhabit the same plane of existence.

Since he captures his subjects in extraordinary situations and strange, often bizarre, garb, I asked Fréger how he militates against the Orientalist gaze. "I think one answer is that I do it the same way, whether I'm in Japan, Europe or India. It's the same process. The way I photograph—it's almost like a protocol—I'm not getting into something for the 'wow' impact. I'm doing a project, a research."

Why should we, as Indians, be excited by this book? After all, we encounter *behrupiyas* often, we see tiger dancers on the streets, we watch the Ramleelas, yakshagana drumbeats ring out through the night on the edges of cities, we return to our villages for *theyyam* and for *bhuta-preta* rituals in our ancestral homes. Some of us cosmopolitans might bring an ironic gaze to such practices, but Fréger has a different angle on these moments of everyday life. "For me, this is not magical," he says. "I photographed some people, most of whom are doing this as a job and are performing in the streets, in theatres, in the temple." He continues, "I tried to stay as much as I could in the reality that there was a person standing in front of me. Not a god... someone."

CHARLES FRÉGER UNOBTRUSIVELY SUGGESTS WHO THE INDIVIDUAL IN HIS PHOTO MIGHT BE BEYOND THE MASKS AND COSTUMES

A close look at the photographs will show that a certain vulnerability lurks behind the swag that the subjects project. There are windows, chinks through which we can glimpse the person behind the mask or the elaborate costume. Fréger unobtrusively suggests who the individual might be beyond the anonymity. He locates his subjects outside the physical environs of the festival/performance space—Manipuri dancers pose in green fields with the sky as their canopy, a blue-faced young Krishna sits on a wooden bench as his tired, all-too-human eyes search for something in the distance; Anuradha Roy, in her